their withdrawal under United States pressure, was regarded as likely to damage Soviet prestige abroad and possibly to affect the internal political position of the present Soviet leadership." A report on media reaction to the resolution of the Cuban crisis prepared for the president and his advisers by the United States Information Agency stated that Cuban media had been silent for three hours, Peking (Beijing) was "sulking," and the West Europeans were discussing the shift in the balance of power toward the United States.[18]

Soviet reporters abroad found themselves on the defensive, obliged to comment on assertions that Khrushchev was no longer in charge in Moscow. The *Pravda* correspondent Yurii Zhukov, meeting with Llewellyn Thompson, denied Western reports to the effect that the abrupt change in Khrushchev's position in his letters to Kennedy suggested that he had been overruled by his colleagues. According to Thompson's report, Zhukov "immediately said that he was certain this wasn't the case and that Mr. Khrushchev was still the boss." Not everyone found that statement reassuring. A few days earlier, when Hervé Alphand, the French ambassador in Washington, had asked Dean Rusk about Khrushchev's drastic changes of position and was shown his letter of October 26 to Kennedy, Alphand remarked that it "showed symptoms of hysteria and mental disequilibrium."[19]

John Kennedy tried to stay away from cheap psychoanalysis or manifestations of triumphalism, just as he had advised his aides to do at the end of the ExCom meeting on October 28. On the following day the *New York Times* published a piece by its prominent journalist James Reston, who was close to Kennedy. It began with the line: "President Kennedy is looking at the Cuban crisis not as a great victory but merely as an honorable accommodation in a single isolated area of the 'cold war.' " The article claimed that Kennedy was not yet drawing general conclusions from the crisis about future relations with the Soviet Union. On the same day, however, Kennedy's adviser Arthur Schlesinger Jr. wrote him a memo suggesting that he deliver a speech doing just that. "The speech should interpret the nature of the victory in such a way as to accustom the nation to the future use of limited force for limited purposes while at the same time